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Extending the Arc of Communication to Afghanistan

WHILE OFFICIALS AND SCRIBES WERE ETCHING THE emperor's messages in the various parts of India, a royal communiqué was promulgated beyond the subcontinent around 259 BCE. The timing of the proclamation, around the tenth year after Ashoka's coronation, makes it broadly contemporaneous with the others that we have just waded through. Unlike those messages, though, this one was in Afghanistan, in the vicinity of Kandahar.

Why did Ashoka get an edict engraved in a region as remote from Pataliputra as Afghanistan, and how may we visualize the desire for making his presence felt there? Speaking historically, Ashoka's imprint in this territory should not surprise us as the region had become part of the Mauryan realm since the time of Chandragupta, when large parts of it were seceded to him by Seleucus. Geographically speaking, however, its remoteness within a generally harsh terrain and climate make it an odd choice for an edict. But then strategically speaking the largely mountainous character of the province had resulted in it being seldom secluded at key points of exit and entry, the Khyber and Kurram passes being much used for access from the south and east, and the Caspian route from Herat towards the north. Mainly for this reason, many millennia before the appearance of Ashoka, specific points in Afghanistan had become a zone of cultural interfaces and trading connections of all kinds.

Ancient artefacts strikingly evocative of links with the West and the East, from Greece and Iran to the heartland of Gangetic India, have turned